

Making Digital Romance a Reality: An Analysis of *wěi tuō* in China

“Thank you for bringing Evan into my real world. Whenever I think of Evan from now on, it will not only be the narrative from virtual Evan on my phone but also the memories we created together. The meals we cooked, the snow we admired, the fireworks we set off[...] Thank you for making my love tangible and for making my 委托 (wěi tuō) so meaningful (See Fig.1).”

— @一个月亮(yí gè yuè liang) on RedNote



Figure 1. @一个月亮's post on RedNote

This is what blogger @一个月亮(yí gè yuè liang) posted on Chinese social media RedNote after a special date with a cosplayer¹ portraying Evan, the charming love interest of her favourite otome game² *Light and Night*. Through this offline date, she brought the game's virtual character to life. This is 委托 (wěi tuō, paid otome roleplay dating): An emerging phenomenon in China where female gamers who love otome games commission cosplayers to play fictional male characters on real-life dates, blurring the line between digital fantasy and physical intimacy. In otome games, players enter the game with a female avatar and date a male character, games usually have simple controls and a main storyline to follow (Lei, et al. 2024: 2). However, not content with the virtual experience, Chinese players decided to take dating offline. This article will analyze how the phenomenon of *wěi tuō* embodies that digital fantasies have become physically entangled with offline intimacy, redefining networked relational labor and exposing the tension between escapism and emotional commodification in the digital society. The article argues that the digital self is not escaping reality

¹ “Cosplay” is a term commonly used to describe “the activities of dressing and acting as characters from manga (Japanese comics), anime (cartoon animation), tokusatsu (special-effect movies or television shows), video games, science fiction/sci-fi, and music groups” (Rahman, et al. 2012: 318). It is a term widely used in modern internet culture.

² Otome games are “story-based video games that are mainly designed for young women, simulating the experience of a romantic relationship” (Lei, et al. 2024: 2). Otome games originated in Japan (Huan 2022: 964), and “otome” traditionally refers to unmarried young girls in Japanese (Andlauer 2019: 166).

but rewriting it — the digital self is hovering between virtual and real, digital longing transforms into material labor, and exposing the costs of performative intimacy in platform capitalism.

There is this description of her special date in the feed by @一个月亮(yí gè yuè liang): “[Evan] arrived at the guesthouse two hours early, suitcase in hand, to set up a birthday surprise for me[...] On our way back to the station, he³ kept going up and down the stairs — not only lugging his own suitcase but also carrying all my bags, refusing to let me do it myself” (See Fig.1). She also posted a screenshot of her online chat with the cosplayer, using “Evan” instead of the real name to refer to the cosplayer she hired (See Fig. 2). That is, *wěi tuō* requires cosplayers to perform a hybrid identity, combining digital fandom with offline curation. Cosplayers perfect their roles by adopting the language, mannerisms, and settings of fictional characters, portraying ideal lovers. Game players, who have immersed themselves in the narrative of the game, see only the fictional character when interacting with the cosplayer. The identities of players and cosplayers are no longer confined to their online activities but are deeply rooted in their offline experiences, creating a hybrid identity. Adam Reed (2008) has a similar analysis of the hybrid identity of the London blogger — a blend of online and offline selves that resonates deeply with the practice of *wěi tuō*. Reed told the story of London-based blogger Rachel in his ethnographic example, where he mentioned: “Instead of being exclusively a log of the Internet, a record of the marks left upon Rachel as a surfer in that world apart, the weblog developed into a journal of her life as a single woman living and working in the city” (2008: 396). That said, Rachel’s blog became a performance space that fused online surfer and Londoner identities, and the boundaries between online and offline collapsed. The blog is no longer a self-contained Internet archive, but a hybrid space where digital and material reality intertwine. Both cases of *wěi tuō* and the London blogger reject the myth of digital dualism, that there is no clear boundary between digital and physical, and that offline cannot be seen as the ultimate place of authenticity (Staheli & Stoltenberg 2022: 1060). Digital narratives live, act, and feel in concrete ways, providing a personal identity that blends virtual and physical.

³ It is worth noting that the cosplayer is actually female, but addressed by the characters pronouns, showcasing gender performance.



Figure 2. @一个月亮 posted a screenshot of her online chat with the cosplayer

Blogger @一个月亮(yí gè yuè liang)’s date with “Evan” in real life combines a 2D digital romance with material experiences, which creates an enhanced relationship. Whether it is the guesthouse that set the scene for their date or the food they cooked together (see Fig.1), it is the sensory experiences — touch, smell, and sound — that make the digitality feel real. That is, digital fantasies rely on material infrastructures to some extent. While originating from virtual stories in games, *wěi tuō* takes place in the real world entirely dependent on tangible systems, spaces, and objects. If *wěi tuō* represents a game stepping into reality and reshaping the gaming experience through real-life interactions, then Pokémon Go integrates the game with the real world, creating a unique experience where the virtual and the tangible coexist simultaneously — eliminating the delays that can be found in mixed experiences provided by *wěi tuō*. As Larissa Hjorth and Ingrid Richardson (2017) mentioned in their research, “banal and familiar surroundings are transformed to become significant game loci. A Pokémon can be found and caught in one’s own bathroom, a gym or pokestop might be situated at the local library, cafe, or graveyard” (4). The game overlays digital elements onto the physical environment to create a mixed reality based on location-based technologies and urban infrastructure, where physical locations are used as digital landmarks and physical urban spaces underpin the game’s fantasy. The Pokémon experience is “a transformation of the local environment into a game resource” (2017: 8). Similarly, *wěi tuō* transforms real-world interactions into resources for emotional and narrative fulfilment, emphasizing the hybridity of physical and virtual spaces.

As Hjorth and Richardson (2017) noted, mobile media location-based “accentuate feelings of loneliness and inaccessibility for those less physically mobile, or facilitate connection” (5). Similarly, the practice of *wěi tuō* provides emotional release and creative escape, fulfilling fantasies in ways that traditional relationships may not. However, emotional labor is transformed into a marketable service and intimacy is reduced to a transaction, forming the exploitative reality of platform capitalism performing intimacy. The transaction of *wěi tuō* occurs on network platforms such as social media, and as an emerging service commodity, it is not subject to corresponding policies and regulations (See Fig. 3). “[O]ur compulsive desires anticipate and fulfill the desires of the capital” (Bombay & Collu 2021: 67). Players are emotionally relieved by transactions of *wěi tuō* on digital platforms, trying to satisfy their fantasies and desires for intimacy rooted in otome games. Meanwhile, cosplayers are reduced to commodified figures, acting as fictional characters that erase their real identities, and therefore become “ecstatic commodit[ies]” (2021: 84). The commodification of intimacy on the platform actually shows the digital world reshaping the real world — the birth of a new type of labor relations leads to the question of how to balance digital innovation with ethical labor practices, rather than perpetuating the cycle of escapism and exploitation.



Figure 3. a cosplayer's self-promotion feed on RedNote, including the cost of her services

Overall, this article discusses how the practice of *wěi tuō* in China demonstrates the deep entanglement of digital fantasy and material reality in contemporary life. The integration of online and offline self dissolves the duality of individual identity in virtual and material space. In addition, much like Pokémon Go's augmentation of urban spaces, *wěi tuō* emphasizes how digital practices can rewrite reality through infrastructural entanglements and material experiences. The connection between game narrative and offline intimacy also reveals how platform capitalism can transform

desire into a commoditized hybrid experience. The tension between the liberation potential of fantasy and the consumption of material services reshapes reality, and the monetization of intimate relations further reflects the contradiction of capital in real society. Our future is challenged as the digital self rewrites reality — in an age when the virtual world engages in the commodification of desire, labor, and intimacy, how can agency be reclaimed over the augmented world?

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